ironed her shirt. ‘Well, she won’t be able to pretend today. Psychological tests are no joke.’

‘Umm . . . any advice for me?’ I asked her as I looked at myself in the mirror. The dress for the day was dark pants with a plain shirt and brogues, as per our instructions. I had tied my hair into a bun, as had already been agreed upon between Hema and me after a half-hour discussion the night before. ‘You’ll do just fine, *nannageleya*.* Just make sure you attempt all the questions and that your answers convey positivity,’ she said as she tied her hair.

‘Well . . . I’ll remember.’ I said.

After the ‘fall-in’ and count-up, and a quick briefing outside the examination hall by Sqn Ldr Yadav, we were seated inside. A digital stopwatch was hung on the front wall and it read ‘0630h’. A projector cast a blank display on a huge whiteboard in front of the wall. Answer sheets were distributed to all. A fan running in one corner made a creaking sound. Other than that, there was absolute silence. ‘So candidates, all set?’ Sqn Ldr Yadav asked. Everyone replied with a ‘yes sir’ in unison. The first test began after the projector flashed, and a countdown from ten ended.

The TAT entailed writing twelve stories about the pictures that were shown to us one after the other on the screen. We were given thirty seconds to glance at a picture and four minutes to write the story, after which the next picture would flash. The twelfth one was a blank screen. Papaji had already spoken to me about this. I was to link this twelfth story to a momentous reflection on my life. *You may not be able to write more than eight to ten lines in the stipulated four minutes. As a rough yardstick, write about two lines for what could have led to this scene, four lines on what you perceive is presently going on in the scene and about four more lines to describe what the logical outcome of the scene could be, according to you,* Papaji had told me. *The views conveyed by you in the story will reflect your social attitude and depict the responsibilities you feel towards others in the society. Do not unnecessarily perceive a problem when it is not shown in the picture—that signals a pessimistic bent of mind. Do not write a wishful story, Gunju, and whatever you write, lead it towards some conclusion.*